

Technical blueprint · v0.1.0

SethuCMS

One CMS for every database.

A security-first gateway that puts one API and one admin app in front of SQL, document and key-value databases, without moving your data.

Open source · MIT · @sethucms on npm and GitHub · 11 October 2026

Every data stack grows its own admin panels

Many databases

Postgres for orders, Firestore for content, Redis for sessions. Each one fits its workload.

Many admin tools

Each database gets its own panel, its own logins and its own audit trail, or none at all.

Apps tied to drivers

Websites and mobile apps call each database directly, so credentials and rules spread everywhere.

Moving everything into one new database is slow and risky. Teams need one control point instead.

A big market, and estimates that disagree

Analyst source	2025 size	Yearly growth
Market Intelo	$2.1B	22.6%
Grand View Research	$1.8B	17.5%
Value Market Research	$1.41B	22.83%
Future Market Insights	$973.8M	22.6%
Market Reports World	$271.2M	9.6%

Say it as a range: headless CMS is roughly $1–2B in 2025, growing in the high teens to low twenties percent a year. These are analyst estimates, not measured data.

Signals that teams want an admin layer over their own database: Directus reports 45M+ downloads and 500K+ projects (self-reported), and Supabase was valued at $10.5B in June 2026.

Why now: open licences are being pulled back

Directus

MIT, then BSL in April 2023, then a source-available licence with v12 in May 2026. Teams report licensing uncertainty as a reason to leave.

NocoDB

AGPL, then a fair-code licence on 9 January 2026. It is no longer an OSI open-source licence.

Earlier cases

Elastic, HashiCorp and Redis relicensed and the community forked: OpenSearch, OpenTofu, Valkey.

Lesson: relicensing after adoption breaks trust. SethuCMS commits to MIT for the core, permanently.

Who we compete with

Product	What it does	Licence	Overlap
Directus	Admin app and API over any SQL database	Source-available (v12)	Highest
Payload	Code-first CMS inside Next.js, now owned by Figma	MIT	High
Hasura	Instant API over your databases, no editor	Varies by version	Medium
Strapi	Node CMS that owns its own schema	MIT plus paid tier	Medium
Supabase	Postgres backend, security rules on Postgres only	Open source	Medium
Sanity, Contentful	Hosted content platforms	Proprietary	Low

We will not win on CMS features. Directus already has drafts, publish and permissions; Payload has versioning and access control.

Where SethuCMS fits

MIT, for good

The core stays MIT, including permissions, audit log and single sign-on already shipped.

One security model

The same field masking, row filters and audit log over SQL and document databases. Directus is SQL only.

Vendor portals

Vendors edit only their own rows, admins oversee, every action is audited. A use case, not a technical first.

Where we are weaker

No users yet. One maintainer. MongoDB and Firestore not verified on real servers. No hosted option. No external security audit.

How it works for an online store

Where the data lives

- Products and prices in Firestore
- Orders and customers in PostgreSQL
- Nothing is moved or copied

What SethuCMS does

- Connects both as read-only
- Shows editors only the products collection
- Orders and customers stay hidden
- Edits are drafts until someone clicks Publish

What the store gets

- One API and a viewer token on the server
- No database drivers or keys in the website
- Every change in the audit log

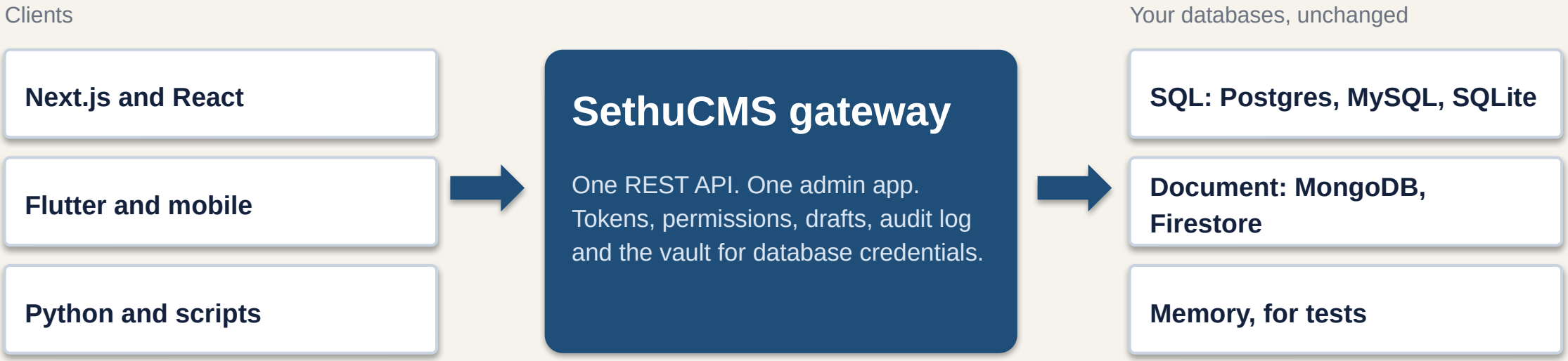
Illustration only: SethuCMS has no customers yet. Vendor and business dashboards for marketplaces are planned, not built.

The same pattern for other kinds of company

Company	Typical databases	What SethuCMS adds
SaaS startup	PostgreSQL for the app, MongoDB for logs and content	One admin app for support and content teams, without database logins
Publisher or blog	Firestore or MongoDB	Drafts, preview links and Publish; the website reads published content only
Agency with many clients	A different database per client	One gateway and admin app, one connection and token per client site
Operations team	Legacy MySQL or SQLite	Read-only views and an audit log instead of direct database access

Illustrative scenarios. The first design-partner deployment is planned for days 30 to 60.

One gateway between your apps and your databases



Bring your own database. SethuCMS reads its structure, builds one content model, and never needs a migration to start.

Credentials never reach the browser

Control	How it works
Tokens	Admin, editor and viewer roles. Only SHA-256 hashes are stored
Vault	AES-256-GCM, bound to the record it protects. Holds database credentials and drafts
Network guard	Cloud metadata and link-local addresses always blocked
Queries	Allowed fields only, parameters only, connections read-only by default
Audit log	Append-only, hash-chained, secrets redacted. Verifiable through the API
Single sign-on	OpenID Connect with PKCE. Tested against a test identity provider only

Also built in: rate limits, idempotency keys and a strict content security policy on the admin page.

Editing never touches the database until Publish

Edit

The editor changes a record in the admin app.

Draft

Saved encrypted in the gateway. The customer database is untouched.

Preview

A signed link shows the draft merged over the live record.

Publish

Checks the record has not changed, then writes through the normal permission path.

If someone else changed the record in the meantime, Publish stops with a conflict error instead of overwriting their work.

Three lines from a website to its content

```
npm install @sethucms/sdk

const cms = new SethuClient({
  baseUrl: process.env.SETHUCMS_BASE_URL,
  token: () => process.env.SETHUCMS_TOKEN,
});

const page = await cms
  .collection(connectionId, 'projects')
  .where(eq('published', true))
  .list();
```

Server side only

The website holds a viewer token in its server environment. Visitors never see it.

Typed and paged

Filters, cursors and errors are handled by the SDK. Python and Dart clients are written but not yet run.

Live today: the gateway on Vercel

Gateway and admin app

Served from one address on Vercel. Sign in with a token.

Shared state

Connections, tokens and audit log live in Firestore, so many serverless functions agree.

Your content

A separate database, added as a read-only connection with only chosen collections exposed.

Ten npm packages

Core, adapters, SDK and kits, all at 0.1.0 under @sethucms.

The Firestore state store passes 7 live tests against the emulator, including two gateways writing at once.

Move data between databases through the gateway

Plan

Dry run lists every collection, field mapping and problem before anything is written.

Run

Copies in the background, one collection at a time. Progress can be followed and cancelled.

Check

Record counts are compared before and after, and each stored record is compared with what was sent.

The source is only read. Verified between memory and PostgreSQL 16 in both directions; other pairs and very large tables are not yet tested.

Where 0.1.0 stands

Verified

- Core and conformance suite pass
- PostgreSQL, MySQL, MariaDB and SQLite on real servers
- Vault, tokens, audit chain, network guard
- Drafts, publish and live preview
- Two gateways on one shared state
- Ten packages published on npm

Not yet verified

- MongoDB and Firestore on the real products
- Container image and cloud deploy workflows end to end
- Single sign-on with a real identity provider
- Load tests and a penetration review
- Any users or revenue: none yet

Next: prove it, then widen it

When	What
First 30 days	Run the container image and deploy workflows end to end. Test MongoDB and Firestore on real servers
Days 30 to 60	First design-partner deployment on non-critical data. Native change capture from the databases
Days 60 to 90	Custom roles and webhook screens in the admin app. Load tests and a security review
After that	Business dashboards, a create-sethucms starter, React and Angular helpers, SQL Server and DynamoDB adapters

Dates are plans, not promises. Each step ships with a public test result.

Upcoming: agents, dashboards and a revenue model

Agentic schema writer

Describe the content you need in plain words. An AI agent drafts the database schema, shows the plan, and applies it only after you approve.

Dashboards

Business and vendor dashboards built on the same permissions, so each person sees only their own rows.

Ads and paid plans

A free plan supported by ads, and paid Pro and Ultra plans without them. Details on the next slide.

None of these are built yet. They sit after the 90-day plan, and the agent will follow the same rule as drafts: it proposes, a person approves.

Planned plans: Free, Pro and Ultra

Free

- Gateway, admin app, drafts, migration
- Ads shown in the middle of the page
- No agentic AI features

Pro

- Everything in Free
- No ads
- Agentic AI features, including the schema writer

Ultra

- Everything in Pro
- No ads
- Agentic AI features, with higher limits [to be decided]
- Discounts on extra databases (future, not available now)

All plans are planned, not live. Prices and limits are not set. The open-source core stays MIT and free to self-host; these plans are for the hosted service.

How it earns: support first, hosting later

Now

- Paid setup and support for design partners
- Grants and sponsorship as runway

Later

- Hosted service with Free, Pro and Ultra plans
- Certified adapters and a plugin marketplace
- Decision on hosting at day 90, based on partner feedback

Never

- A licence that limits who may use it
- Taking back features that already shipped

MIT lets anyone host SethuCMS. Our protection is the trademark, the hosted service, adapter certification and expertise, not the licence.

What we commit to, and can prove

Licence

The core stays MIT. Contributors sign off commits (DCO), so contributions stay under MIT. A trademark policy protects the name.

Security

Security policy and private vulnerability reporting from day one. Targets: reply in 3 business days, fix critical issues in 14.

Support

Best effort for the community. Design partners get a named contact in IST business hours and a monthly call. No 24x7 promise.

Evidence

A public 30, 60 and 90 day plan, and a monthly update with installs, downloads and contributors.

The ask matches the stage: pre-traction

What we are asking for

- Introductions to design partners who run real databases
- A grant or programme place, such as the GitHub Secure Open Source Fund ($10,000 per project)
- An incubator introduction for the Startup India Seed Fund, once incorporated
- A small pre-seed cheque, sized to 9 to 12 months of runway [amount to be set]

What we are not asking for

A scaled seed round. With zero users, the honest comparison is a small pre-seed, not a median seed.

What investors will see monthly: real installs, @sethucms/sdk downloads, outside contributors, issue response time and named design partners. No bought stars.

Connect your databases. Keep your data where it is.

Try it

npm install @sethucms/sdk

Read the code

github.com/SethuCMS

Work with us

Looking for design partners to run it on real data.

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